

Topic 13: Choosing the Right AI Tool

13.1 A Decision Framework

- What is the input type? (text, image, audio, document, code, data)
- What is the desired output? (text, image, structured data, code, summary, action)
- How important is accuracy? (high: use larger models and verify all facts; low: any capable tool works)
- Is data sensitivity a concern? (yes: use enterprise tier or run a local model)
- What is the budget? (free: ChatGPT / Claude free tiers; paid: match the cost to the value created)
- Is this a one-off or a repeated task? (repeated: build a prompt template or automation)

13.2 Quick Reference Comparison

- Best overall AI assistant: ChatGPT (GPT-4o) or Claude 3.5 Sonnet -- try both for your use case
- Best for very long documents: Claude (200k token context window)
- Best for real-time information with sources: Perplexity AI
- Best for coding (in editor): GitHub Copilot; for code explanation: Claude or ChatGPT
- Best for artistic images: Midjourney; precise/literal images: DALL-E 3; free/custom: Stable Diffusion
- Best for meeting summaries: Otter.ai or Fathom (free for Zoom)
- Best for Microsoft 365 users: Microsoft Copilot; for Google Workspace users: Gemini

13.3 Staying Up to Date

- The best AI tool today may be outperformed in 3 months -- build flexible habits, not rigid tool dependencies
- Newsletters: The Rundown AI, TLDR AI, Ben's Bites, The Batch -- weekly summaries of what is new and worth trying
- Test new tools when they launch: 10--15 minutes of hands-on use reveals more than any review article
- Focus on transferable skills: prompt engineering, critical evaluation, and workflow design remain relevant as tools evolve
- Tool directories: there.is (there.is/t/ai-tools) and Futurepedia (futurepedia.io) catalogue new AI tools weekly

13.4 The Near Future of AI Tools

- AI agents: tools will increasingly complete multi-step tasks autonomously -- browse, book, file, and email on your behalf

- Persistent memory and personalisation: tools will learn your preferences, writing style, and recurring tasks over time
 - Invisible integration: AI will be embedded as a feature in every app -- a search bar, an inbox, a spreadsheet
 - Voice-first interfaces: interacting with AI through natural conversation rather than typing prompts
 - Prepare: the practitioners who thrive will be those who know what to delegate to AI and what to keep for human judgement
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